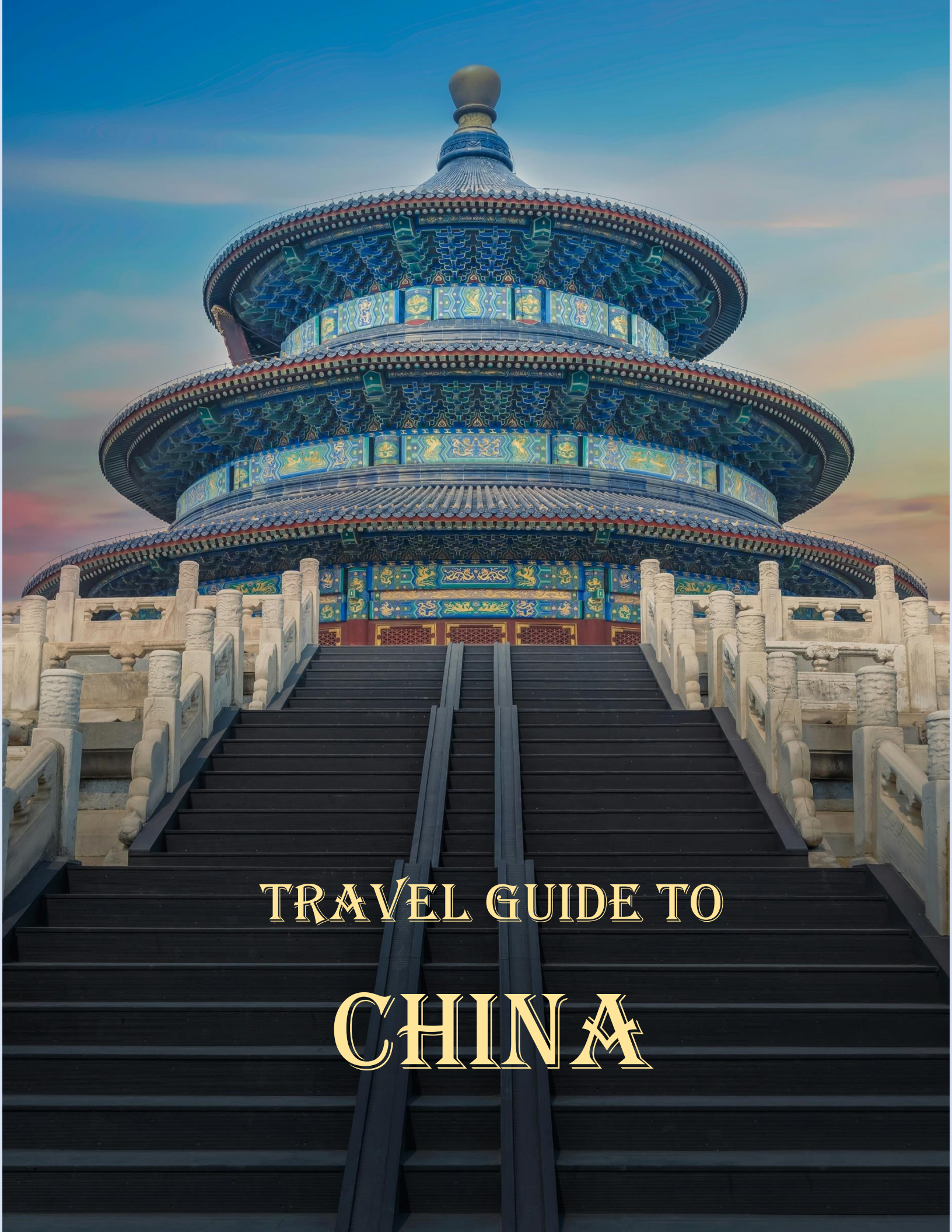




TRAVEL GUIDE TO CHINA

Why China

China does not greet visitors—it challenges them. It is a land of contrasts, where ancient whispers meet modern energy, and every corner tells a story. From the Great Wall to the Li River, from bustling Xi'an to futuristic Shanghai, China transforms those who dare to explore it.

*It is not a journey across a map—it is a leap into a living legend.
China is waiting. Step into the story.*

About China

- **Climate**

China's climate is hugely diverse—scorching summers in the south, freezing winters in the north. Pack for the season, and expect heavy summer rains in most regions.

- **Currency**

The currency is the Yuan (CNY, symbol ¥). The exchange rate is roughly 7.2 CNY to 1 USD. China is largely cashless, so downloading Alipay and WeChat Pay is essential for almost every purchase.

- **Safety**

China is very safe for tourists. Watch out for pickpockets in crowded markets and metro stations. Emergency numbers: 110 for police, 120 for medical help. Expect routine security checks at stations and major sights.

- **Vaccinations**

No mandatory vaccinations are required for most travelers, except a yellow fever certificate if arriving from an affected country. Recommended jabs include Hepatitis A, Hepatitis B, and Typhoid.

- **Entry Requirements**

Citizens of 75+ countries enjoy 30-day visa-free entry, while 54 countries qualify for a 10-day visa-free transit in major cities like Beijing and Shanghai. Always check the latest rules before you fly.

- **Time Zone**

Despite its vast size, all of China follows a single time zone: UTC+8. Daylight Saving Time is not observed.

- **Transportation**

High-speed trains are the best way to travel between cities; metros are excellent within them. Use Didi for ride-hailing, and book train tickets through the official 12306 platform using your passport.

- **Language**

Mandarin is the official language. English is spoken in hotels and major tourist areas. Learn just two words—"Ni Hao" (Hello) and "Xiexie" (Thank you)—and locals will warmly appreciate the effort.

- **Cuisine**

Chinese food is incredibly varied. Don't miss Peking Duck, fiery Hot Pot, and Xiao Long Bao (soup dumplings). Explore night markets for street food, but always choose busy stalls with long queues for the freshest bites.

- **Cultural Etiquette**

Never stick chopsticks upright in a bowl of rice—it's a funeral symbol. Offer and receive gifts with both hands, and politely refuse them twice before accepting. Dress modestly at temples, and always greet the eldest person first.

- **Attractions**

Top must-sees: the Great Wall, the Forbidden City, the Terracotta Warriors, and Zhangjiajie's surreal peaks (which inspired "Avatar"). Visit these world-famous sites early in the morning to beat the massive crowds.

Travelers Must See



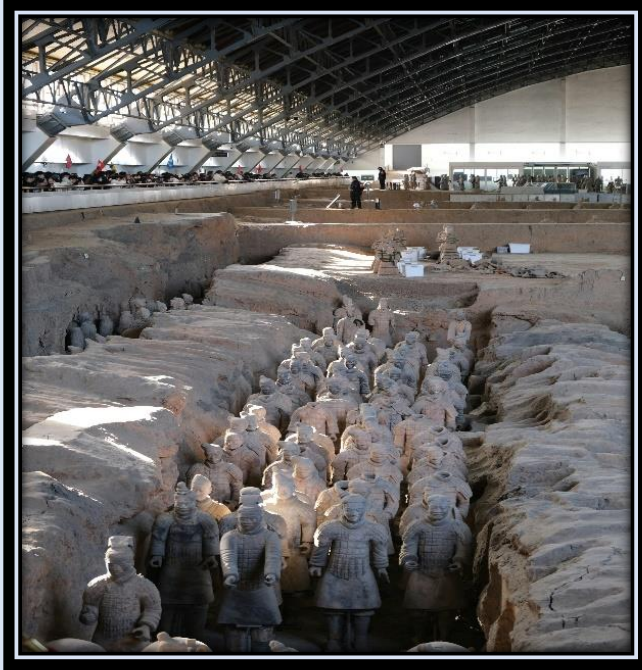
The Great Wall of China

Imagine a dragon of stone and earth, stretching for thousands of miles across mountains and deserts, its spine rising and falling with the contours of the land. This is the Great Wall, a monument to human determination that took over two thousand years to build. Standing on its ancient watchtowers, the wind carries whispers of soldiers who once guarded the empire. It is not just a wall—it is the ultimate symbol of China's strength and endurance. For those who walk its path, every step is a journey through history itself.

The Forbidden City

For nearly five centuries, this vast palace complex was a secret world—off-limits to ordinary people, accessible only to emperors and their courts. Today, the Forbidden City stands as the world's largest and best-preserved wooden palace complex, with nearly 10,000 rooms wrapped in golden roofs and crimson walls. Wandering through its courtyards, one can almost hear the echoes of imperial ceremonies and whispered conspiracies. It is the soul of imperial China, frozen in time.





The Terracotta Warriors

Buried for over 2,200 years, an entire army of clay soldiers stands in silent formation, guarding the tomb of China's first emperor. Thousands of life-sized warriors, each with a unique face, expression, and hairstyle, were crafted to accompany their ruler into the afterlife. Discovered by farmers in 1974, this underground legion remains one of the most astonishing archaeological finds in history. Standing before them, one feels the weight of an empire that shaped the world.

Zhangjiajie's Avatar Mountains

Towering pillars of quartzite sandstone rise from the mist like something from another planet. These surreal peaks, which inspired the floating mountains of the movie "Avatar," pierce the clouds in a landscape that defies belief. Glass elevators and skywalks offer vertigo-inducing views, but the real magic lies in the feeling of stepping into a world where nature has abandoned all rules. Zhangjiajie is not a place—it is a dream made of stone and fog.



The Li River & Yangshuo's Karst Mountains



Picture emerald waters winding between limestone peaks that rise like ancient teeth from the earth. This is the landscape immortalized on China's 20-yuan banknote—a scene of such breathtaking beauty that it has inspired poets for centuries. A cruise down the Li River reveals floating fishermen, water buffalo, and villages that seem to belong to another era. In Yangshuo, travelers cycle through rice paddies and feel as though they have stepped inside a living ink painting.

Jiuzhaigou Valley



A valley where the water is impossibly blue, turquoise, and emerald—over a hundred lakes, each more vivid than the last. Waterfalls tumble between them, and ancient forests cling to the mountainsides. This is Jiuzhaigou, a UNESCO World Heritage site that feels like nature's private art gallery. In autumn, the foliage erupts into fiery reds and golds, reflecting off the crystalline lakes in a spectacle that leaves visitors speechless.

The Rainbow Mountains of Zhangye



Twenty-four million years of geological history, revealed in layers of red, yellow, and green that stripe across ancient rock. The Zhangye Danxia landform is nature's own masterpiece—a mountain range that looks like a giant painting, glowing most brilliantly at sunrise and sunset. Recognized as one of the world's most unusual landscapes, it proves that the Earth can be just as surreal as any artist's imagination.

Huangshan – The Yellow Mountains



For over a thousand years, this mountain range has been the muse of Chinese painters and poets, inspiring over 20,000 poems. Granite peaks pierce through seas of clouds, twisted pines cling to sheer cliffs, and hot springs offer quiet refuge. Watching the sunrise from Huangshan's summit, as the world below slowly turns golden, is to witness the very essence of Chinese beauty—a scene so perfect it feels like a dream.

The Bund, Shanghai



On one side of the Huangpu River, colonial-era buildings whisper stories of Shanghai's glamorous past. On the other, futuristic skyscrapers pierce the sky, led by the iconic Oriental Pearl Tower. This is the Bund—the heart of modern China, where history and ambition collide in a dazzling skyline. At night, the city lights reflect off the water in a spectacle that captures the relentless energy of this global metropolis.

The Potala Palace, Lhasa

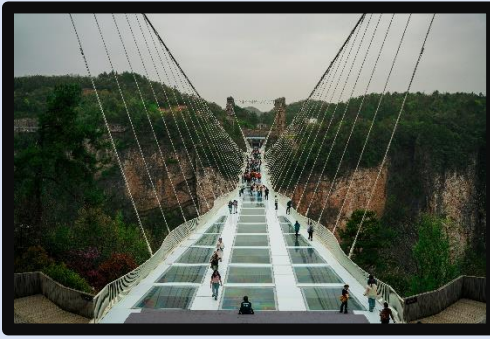


Perched high above the Tibetan capital, this colossal palace rises like a fortress of faith against the vast plateau sky. With its white and crimson walls, golden roofs, and thousands of rooms, the Potala Palace is both a architectural wonder and the spiritual heart of Tibetan Buddhism. It stands as a testament to devotion, offering breathtaking views and an aura of profound reverence that touches every visitor who climbs its ancient steps.

Activities To Do

China is a land of experiences that go far beyond sightseeing—it's a place where every activity tells a story and awakens the senses. Here are the most unforgettable things a traveler can do in the Middle Kingdom

These are not mere activities—they are stories waiting to be lived, memories waiting to be made. China does not just offer things to do; it offers transformations, challenges, and moments of pure, unfiltered wonder.



Walk on Air at Zhangjiajie's Glass Bridges

Suspended between soaring quartzite pillars that pierce the clouds—the very mountains that inspired the floating world of *Avatar*—a transparent bridge dares visitors to step into the void. Far below, ancient forests carpet the valley floor. Above, the sky seems close enough to touch. This is not merely a walk; it is a test of courage wrapped in breathtaking beauty, where the boundary between earth and sky dissolves beneath your feet.



Climb the "Sky Ladder" Via Ferrata

For those who crave adrenaline, Zhangjiajie offers something far more visceral: a 168-meter iron ladder bolted to a sheer cliff face, swaying gently as climbers inch upward into the mist. Dubbed "China's highest via ferrata," this protected climbing route transforms strangers into teammates, fear into exhilaration. At the summit, a ceremonial bell awaits—three rings to announce your triumph over the impossible.



Paddleboard Through Pristine Karst Waters

On the glassy, jade-green waters of the Hongshui River in Guangxi, limestone towers rise sharply from the banks while silvery fish leap in unison beneath your board. This is paddleboarding at its most theatrical—a cardio workout set against a backdrop so pristine it feels like a dream. Here, the water is so clear you can watch fish dart beneath you as you glide through a landscape that has remained untouched for centuries.



Camp Beneath the Stars at Yamdrok Lake

Far from the neon glow of cities, on the shores of a turquoise lake cradled by snow-capped peaks in Tibet, a canvas of stars unfolds each night with breathtaking clarity. Camping by Yamdrok Lake is an invitation to slow down—to breathe the thin, pure air and watch the sky transform from deep blue to inky black, scattered with a billion diamonds. It is nature's own cathedral, silent and sublime.



Trek Through the World's Deepest Canyon

Tiger Leaping Gorge, one of the deepest canyons on Earth, is not for the faint of heart. The Yangtze River thunders far below, while 5,000-meter peaks loom above as you navigate narrow trails carved into sheer cliff faces. It is a grueling hike, but every aching step rewards you with views that make the struggle unforgettable—a raw, untamed encounter with nature at its most dramatic.



Ride the Bullet Train Across the Country

China's high-speed rail network is the world's largest, hurtling passengers across vast distances at speeds that rival flight. But this is no ordinary commute—it is a window into the nation's soul, where futuristic cities give way to ancient rice terraces and mountain villages in the span of a single journey. Sitting back as the landscape blurs past is an activity in itself, a meditation on motion and the relentless pulse of modern China.



Step Back in Time with a Hanfu Photoshoot

In the ancient capital of Xi'an or the timeless water towns of Suzhou, the past is not just a memory—it is an invitation. Here, a traveler can trade their modern clothes for the flowing silks of a *Hanfu*, the traditional attire of the Han Chinese. This is more than dressing up; it is a form of time travel. As the robes are tied and the delicate round fan is held, the traveler begins to feel the elegance of a bygone era. Wandering through the Tang Dynasty-style streets under soft lantern light, every step feels like a scene from an ancient painting. It's an immersive journey where the traveler is not just seeing history, but becoming a part of it, with countless photo opportunities to capture the magic and carry this unique memory home.



Craft Your Own Heritage in a Hands-on Workshop

Across China, ancient skills are being passed from master to traveler, turning tourists into artisans. In the ancient porcelain capital of Jingdezhen, visitors can feel the cool, wet clay spin beneath their fingers on a potter's wheel. In the historic city of Datong, they can create intricate copper rubbings, an intangible cultural heritage where every tap of the hammer reveals a story etched in metal. With a master craftsman guiding their hands, they might even learn the delicate art of Suzhou embroidery or the vibrant craft of lacquer fan painting. The reward is not just a beautiful, finished product, but a profound connection to the culture—a unique souvenir that was created by their own hands, infused with the spirit of China itself.



Become Part of the Story at an Interactive Opera

In cities like Wuhan, the ancient art of Chinese opera is breaking free from the stage. Here, the audience is no longer a passive observer but an active participant in a time-enduring romance. In these immersive performances, visitors step into the world of the protagonists, experiencing the drama, music, and emotion firsthand. The vivid performances and interactive elements make the stories of the past come alive in a way that is both exhilarating and deeply moving. It transforms a centuries-old art form into a personal, unforgettable adventure, proving that some stories are best experienced from the inside.

China offers a different kind of treasure: the chance to step directly into its living culture. These aren't just activities to watch; they are experiences that transform a traveler into a participant in a story that has been unfolding for thousands of years. Here are three of the most



Chinese New Year (Spring Festival) – The Rebirth of Hope

Imagine stepping into a land draped in golden red, where lanterns sway on every corner and the aroma of dumplings rises from every home. This is the Spring Festival, the grandest celebration in China and the most important national holiday. It is the time when families journey from every corner of the earth to gather around the reunion dinner, and the sky explodes with fireworks meant to drive away evil spirits. It is not merely a celebration—it is a rebirth of hope and joy.

Date: February 17



Lantern Festival – The Night of Light and Love

Two weeks after the New Year, another enchanting moment arrives: the Lantern Festival. Streets are adorned with thousands of colorful lanterns, some carrying riddles waiting to be solved. People gather to eat sweet rice balls called *Yuanxiao*, while the sky glitters with countless flying lanterns carrying wishes to the heavens. It is a night when love and hope shine brightly in every Chinese heart.

Date: March 3



Dragon Boat Festival – A Race of Legends

Prepare to hear the pounding of drums and roaring cheers! On the fifth day of the fifth lunar month, elaborately decorated dragon boats race fiercely across rivers and lakes. This festival commemorates the patriotic poet *Qu Yuan*, who drowned himself in a river in protest against injustice. People eat *Zongzi* (rice dumplings wrapped in bamboo leaves) while watching this thrilling aquatic spectacle. It is a festival of energy and team spirit.

Date: June 19



Chinese National Day – An Explosion of Pride

On October 1st, all of China pauses to celebrate its National Day. Red flags flutter on every street, and spectacular fireworks displays light up the skies of major cities. It is a full week of celebrations and parades showcasing the strength and unity of this great nation. It is an opportunity to witness China at its most passionate and proud.

Date: October 1

Water-Splashing Festival – The Ritual of Blessing and Joy

In Yunnan Province in southwestern China, water transforms into a symbol of blessing and goodness. During this festival celebrated by the *Dai* people, people splash water on each other in a ritual expressing purification and wishes for happiness. It is a unique and joyful experience, unlike any other festival in China.

Date: April 13–15 annually



Cities Must Visit



Beijing – Where History Whispers

Beijing is the soul of imperial China. Walk through the crimson gates of the Forbidden City, where emperors once ruled from 10,000 rooms. Stand atop the Great Wall, a stone dragon snaking across mountain ridges for thousands of miles. At the Temple of Heaven, emperors prayed for harvests. This city breathes history at every corner.

Best time: April–May, September–October

Shanghai – The City of Tomorrow

Shanghai is China's futuristic dream. Marvel at the sky-piercing towers of Lujiazui, especially the Shanghai Tower. Stroll along The Bund, where colonial buildings whisper tales of the past, while modern neon lights blaze across the river. Wander through peaceful Yu Garden for a taste of old China. Shanghai dazzles with bold energy.

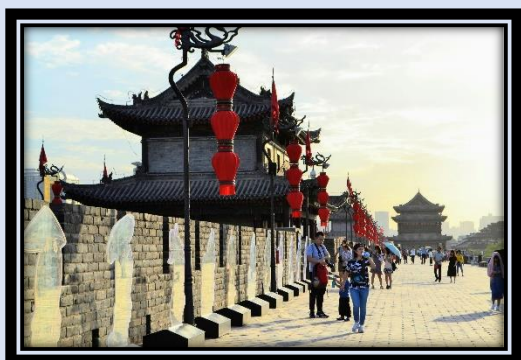
Best time: March–May, October–November



Xi'an – Where Legends Begin

Xi'an is the starting point of the ancient Silk Road. Gaze upon the silent, life-sized Terracotta Warriors standing guard for over 2,000 years. Cycle along the best-preserved ancient city wall in China. Lose yourself in the aromatic Muslim Quarter, where spices and history fill the air. Xi'an brings ancient stories to life.

Best time: April–June, September



Chengdu – Land of Pandas and Peace

Chengdu is a city that knows how to slow down. Watch giant pandas munch bamboo at the breeding base—a moment of pure joy. Sip tea in a traditional teahouse like a local, surrounded by peaceful gardens. Life here moves at a gentle pace, reminding you to savor every moment.

Best time: March–June, September–November





Hong Kong – Where East Meets West

Hong Kong is a dazzling fusion of cultures. Ride the Peak Tram for breathtaking views over Victoria Harbour. Cruise across the water on the historic Star Ferry, watching skyscrapers light up at sunset. Explore the bustling markets of Mong Kok and find peace at the giant Buddha on Lantau Island. Hong Kong pulses with electric energy.

Best time: October–December, March–April

Macau – Asia's Glittering Gem

Macau is a surprising blend of Portuguese charm and Chinese tradition. Stroll through the cobblestone streets of its historic center, a UNESCO site, and marvel at the ruins of St. Paul's Cathedral. Try the famous egg tarts and feel the buzz of its glamorous casinos. Macau is a city of contrasts and delights.

Best time: October–December, April–May



Hangzhou – Paradise on Earth

Hangzhou is pure serenity. Drift across West Lake, surrounded by ancient pagodas, willow trees, and distant green hills. Visit Lingyin Temple, one of China's oldest Buddhist sanctuaries, tucked among bamboo groves. Spring brings cherry blossoms, painting the city in soft pinks and whites. Hangzhou is a poet's dream.

Best time: March–May, September–November

Suzhou – The Venice of the East

Suzhou is a garden lover's paradise. Wander through UNESCO-listed classical gardens, where water, rocks, and pavilions create perfect harmony. Glide along ancient canals in a wooden boat, passing under stone bridges and traditional white-walled homes. Suzhou is also famous for its exquisite silk craftsmanship.

Best time: March–May, September–November



Where To Stay

Imagine that every hotel in China is a portal to a different world. Some carry you back to eras of imperial grandeur, others place you in the heart of a futuristic glass city, and many offer the warmth of home without weighing down your budget. China is not just a destination; it is a living canvas of accommodations, each telling a unique story.

In China, every hotel carries a story. Some tell tales of luxury and opulence, while others speak of simplicity and warmth. The beauty is that you are free to choose the story that fits your budget and your spirit of adventure. Whether you choose to sleep among the clouds, in the embrace of the mountains, or in a traditional alleyway, China awaits to make your stay an unforgettable chapter of your journey.



- In Shanghai, where the sky meets the earth, stands the J Hotel Shanghai Tower—the highest hotel in the world, where you sleep above the clouds and wake up to a view only birds can see. Nearby, the Peace Hotel whispers tales of the 1920s, while the Waldorf Astoria offers a magical blend of colonial-era glamour and the city's modern skyline.
- In Beijing, the Peninsula stands as a crown jewel of hospitality, while the Bvlgari flows with quiet elegance like a living work of art.
- In the mountains of Sichuan, Rissai Valley Resort offers a peaceful sanctuary where luxury meets untouched nature.

Explore & Book Hotel



If you are looking for quality at a reasonable price, China is filled with hidden gems

- Beijing Zhongan Hotel – tucked in a traditional *hutong* alley, close to the Forbidden City.
- Motchan Hotel – in Shanghai, with spacious rooms and a breakfast buffet often rated the best in China.
- Ramada Xi'an – in the heart of the ancient city, offering 4-star quality at an economic price.
- Orange Hotel – in Chengdu, with modern rooms near Kuanzhai Alley.
- Junle Hotel – in Guangzhou, fully renovated in 2020 with competitive prices.
- Green Tree Inn – a chain spread across all major cities, a safe and reliable choice for budget travelers.

Explore & Book Hotel

Food



Imagine China as one giant dining table stretching from the Himalayan mountains to the Pacific coast. Every region whispers its own recipe, and every city tells its story through flavor. Food here is not just fuel—it is edible history and art on a plate.



In China, every meal is a journey—across time, across landscapes, and into the hearts of millions who perfected these flavors over centuries. Whether you are savoring Peking Duck in a grand hall, dunking meat into a bubbling hot pot in a narrow alley, or biting into a dumpling from a street cart, you are not just eating—you are tasting a living legend.



Restaurant

From emperors to street vendors, dining in China is never just a meal—it is an experience. In the grand dining halls of Beijing and Shanghai, legendary chefs transform simple ingredients into edible masterpieces, where Peking Duck is carved with theatrical precision and hot pots bubble with aromatic spices. Yet the true soul of Chinese cuisine lives in the bustling local eateries, where steaming baskets of dumplings and sizzling woks tell stories passed down through generations. Whether you seek the artistry of Michelin-starred temples of gastronomy or the comforting chaos of a neighbourhood noodle shop, every meal is a journey through China's rich culinary heritage.



Discover and search for the best Chinese restaurants.

Transportations



High-Speed Rail

The silver dragon of steel and glass, covering over 42,000 km at 350 km/h. From Beijing to Shanghai in just 4.5 hours. Book with your passport.

[Get Ticket](#)



Metro & Subway

The silent pulse of every major city. Clean, modern, English-friendly. Just scan a QR code from Alipay or WeChat and go.

[Get Ticket](#)



Didi, Taxis & Buses

Didi is China's Uber, easy to use in English. Taxis are everywhere. Buses are the cheapest way to see local life.

[Get Ticket](#)



Shared Bikes & Ferries

Unlock a yellow, blue, or green bike with a QR code for the last mile. In Shanghai, take a ferry across the Huangpu River for a breezy view of the skyline.

[Get Ticket](#)

When To Go

China does not have one season—it has four completely different personalities, each offering a unique invitation to explore.

Spring (March to May) is when China awakens. Cherry blossoms paint the streets of Hangzhou in soft pinks and whites, the weather is mild, and the landscapes turn lush and green. It is the perfect time for outdoor adventures and wandering through ancient gardens.

Summer (June to August) brings warmth and excitement—but also rain. The days are long, the nights are alive, and the countryside bursts into full bloom. It is the season of lotus flowers and outdoor festivals, but do pack an umbrella; afternoon showers are a daily ritual.

Autumn (September to November) is perhaps the most enchanting chapter. The summer heat fades into crisp, golden days. The leaves turn fiery red and orange in places like Jiuzhaigou, the skies are crystal clear, and the air carries the scent of harvest. This is the season of mooncakes and breathtaking sunsets.

Winter (December to February) transforms China into a wonderland of ice and snow. Harbin's Ice Festival turns the city into a frozen palace of dazzling sculptures. While the north is cold and dry, the south remains mild, making it a season of contrasts and cozy, festive celebrations.

Plan Your Trip

Every great journey begins with a single decision—the moment you stop dreaming and start planning.

China is not a destination you simply visit; it is a story you step into. From the moment you land, you are no longer a spectator—you become part of a living legend. Imagine walking along the ancient stones of the Great Wall, feeling the weight of centuries beneath your feet. Picture yourself standing before the silent Terracotta Army, each warrior guarding secrets of an empire long gone. Envision the neon glow of Shanghai's skyline reflecting off the Huangpu River as you sip tea in a hidden garden.

But here is the secret: the best adventures are not left to chance. They are crafted. They are planned. They are booked.

With just a few clicks, you can unlock a world of wonders—from the misty peaks of Zhangjiajie to the tranquil waters of West Lake. Flights, trains, hotels, and tours are all within your reach. The high-speed rail is waiting to carry you across the country in hours. The metro systems are ready to guide you through bustling cities. And the local street food vendors are eager to share flavours that have been perfected over generations.

The question is not if you will go—but when and how.

Do not wait for the perfect moment. Create it. China is calling, and its stories are waiting to be written—by you.

Discover and search for the best travel deals to China. Your adventure begins with one click.

Plan Your Trip

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[GetYourGuide](#) is the world's leading online marketplace for travel experiences. Founded in 2009, it connects travelers with over 200,000 tours, attractions, and activities across more than 18,000 cities worldwide. From skip-the-line museum tickets and guided walking tours to cooking classes, multi-day adventures, and even West End shows, GetYourGuide makes it easy to turn travel inspiration into unforgettable memories.

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[Aviasales](#) is a metasearch engine for flights that searches and compares prices from over 800 airlines and travel agencies. Founded in 2007, it has grown to become one of the most trusted flight search platforms globally, with a presence in over 40 languages and more than 200 countries.

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